

Rules of Play

Illinois Shuffleboard Association

Version 2.0

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1. Playing Shuffleboard

1.1 Game

1.1.1 Object

The object of the game is to propel discs, using a cue, toward the scoring area at the opposite end of the court to score, prevent your opponent from scoring, or both.

1.1.2 Game Types

There are three types of games, based on the number of players:

- Walking Singles - two individual people compete against one another, playing odd-numbered frames from the head of the court (where the scoreboard is) and even-numbered frames from the foot of the court (the opposite end)
- Non-Walking Singles - two individual people compete against one another, playing from a single end of the court; another match may happen simultaneously on the other end of the court
- Doubles - two teams of two people compete against each other, with one member from team A and B on each end of the court

There are two different game-end scenarios:

- Points Game - a game is complete once a player or team has reached 75 points
- Frames Game - a game is complete once a predetermined number of frames have been played - frame games must have an even number of frames

The player or team with the most points after a game-end scenario has been met is the winner. In the event of a tie, see [Tie Games](#).

1.1.3 Divisions

The Illinois Shuffleboard Association does not separate tournaments or leagues by gender or sex.

1.1.4 Amendments

The Tournament Director (TD) or league manager(s) may amend any of these rules for the event. Any amendments or omissions will be announced before the event begins.

1.2 Equipment

1.2.1 Discs

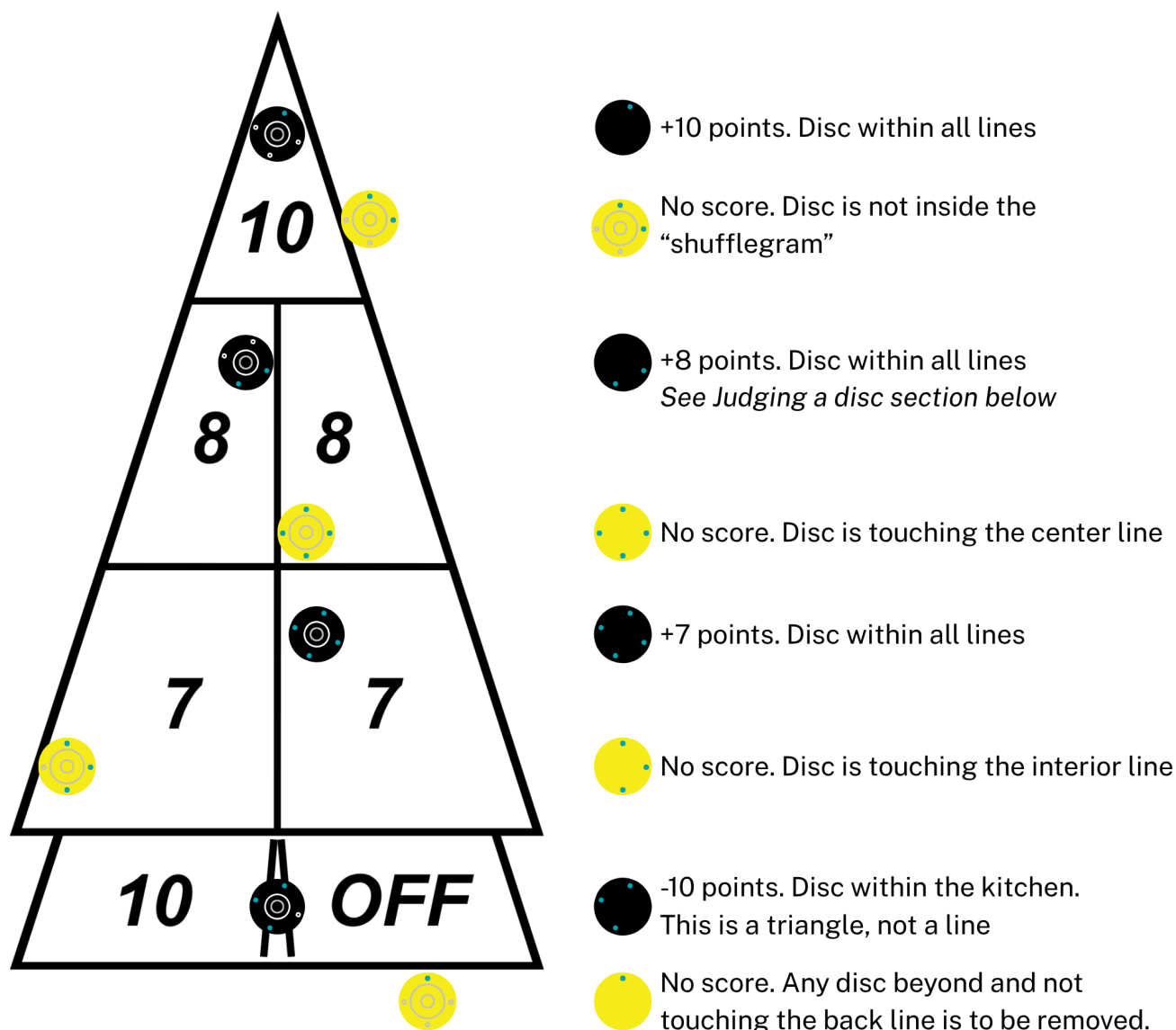
Discs shall be no less than 9/16" and no more than 1" in thickness, 6" in diameter, and no less than 11 1/2 ounces in weight. Four (4) discs shall be colored yellow, four (4) colored black. These eight (8) discs comprise a set. (Other color combinations may be used.) Care should be taken that all discs in a set shall be uniform in weight and thickness.

1.3 Score

1.3.1 Scoring a Frame

A frame is complete when the eighth disc is shot and all discs come to a stop. When a frame is complete, score all discs on the scoring area within, but not touching, the lines. The separation triangle in the 10-Off area is not considered a line. In a points game, play continues until all discs have been shot in that frame even if the game-end points total (i.e. 75) has been reached.

Scoring discs do not cancel each other out. If both players have a scoring “8” disc, they both receive 8 points.



This diagram depicts a frame score of zero for yellow and 15 for black.

1.3.2 Live Discs/Line Calls

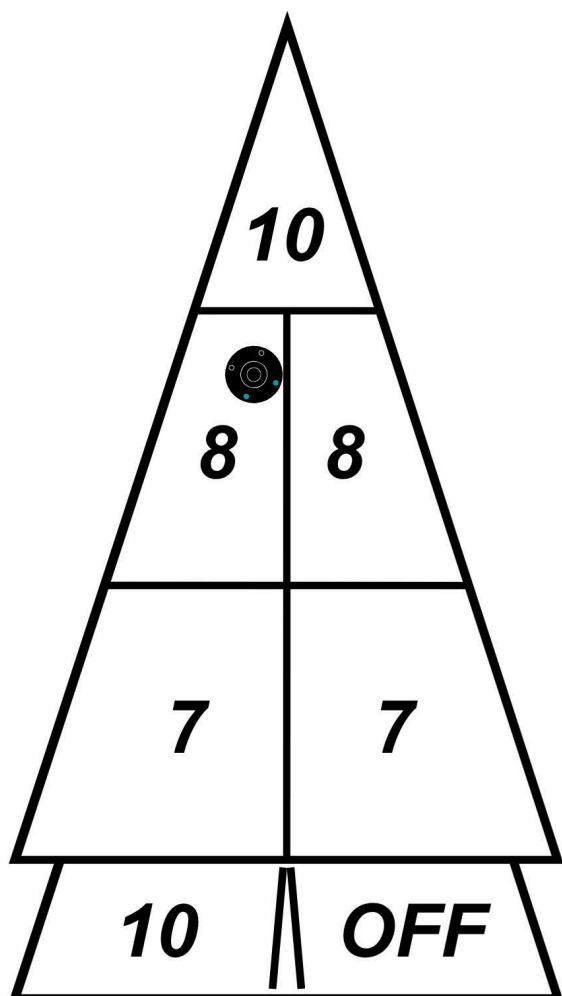
Players that are shooting may walk down the alley to check the location of live discs.

In doubles or non-walking singles, players opposite the shooting end are tasked with determining which discs are IN or OUT. In walking singles, opposing players both check the disc to come to a mutual decision.

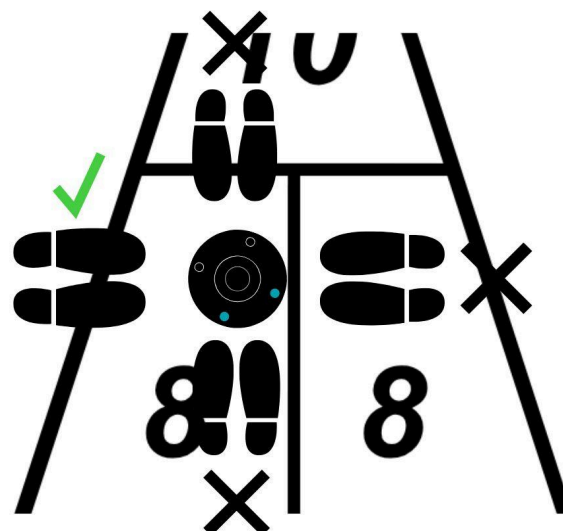
In the event of disagreement on whether a disc is IN or OUT, the TD or their official(s) shall make the third and final call. In unofficiated play, request a final call from an agreed upon third party. If one is not available to make the call, replay the frame.

1.3.3 Judging a Disc

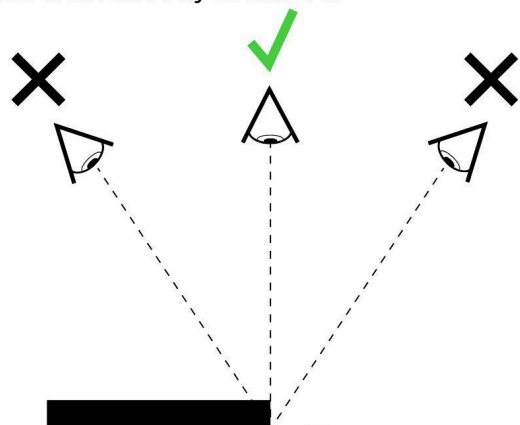
When judging a disc in relation to lines, the person shall look directly down over the disc. A mounted disc, or disc resting on top of another disc, happens sometimes when players use excessive force in shooting and shall be counted if within the scoring area. Each disc shall be judged separately according to scoring rules.



The disc shown above warrants a closer look.



Must be judged from BEHIND the disc and viewed from directly overhead.



The zoomed in view on the right shows where a disc is judged from, with the disc between you and the line and your eye directly OVER the disc edge. Any other angle will risk improper calls.

1.3.4 Scoreboard

A	B		
-	7		
10	7		
3	15		
4	15		
12	5		
19	12		
19	12		
19	20		

Players at the head record the scoring discs after each frame.

Before a game begins, the scoreboard must have a designation of which color leads, either via a tournament bar on its side or tick marks drawn on the scoreboard. This diagram shows both.

See: [Shooting Order](#).

A zero can be indicated in any manner of the scorers choosing so as long as all players agree (i.e. dash, zero, slashed zero).

Negative numbers are depicted with a circle so that they are easier to read from the foot of the court.

1.3.5 Error In Scoring

If an error occurs in scoring on the scoreboard at the end of the frame and it is discovered before the next frame is completed, the error must be corrected. Otherwise the score as indicated on the scoreboard shall stand, unless both sides agree on the correction.

1.3.6 Tie Games

If opposing players/teams have the same score after reaching the game-end scenario for their [game type](#), the tie must be broken.

To break the tie, two additional frames will be played, repeating until the score is no longer tied.

In a points game, if the tie-breaking frames result in scores below 75 points, nevertheless breaking the tie, the game is complete with the higher scoring player/team the winner.

If there was a color change in the game, players continue to play on the colors they were playing at the end of the game.

1.4 Order of Operations

1.4.1 Determining Color and Player Placement

At the start of a match, competitors will flip a coin or play a game like *Rock Paper Scissors*. The winner either chooses which color to play in the first game of the match or defers to their opponent.

In doubles matches, the team that chose the color decides which of their players will play on each end of each court. The other team then decides where their players will play. Players must continue to play from the same ends of the court in additional games of the match.

Example:

Alice and Bob are playing a best-of-3 doubles match against Chris and Diane. Alice and Bob win the coin toss, but decide to defer the color choice. Chris and Diane choose to play as Yellow in game 1, assign Chris to the head of the court, and assign Diana to the foot of the court. Alice and Bob then assign Bob to the head of the court and Alice to the foot of the court. In game 2, Chris and Diana play Black and Bob and Alice play Yellow.

Alternatively, a tournament may pre-determine which color each competitor plays in game 1 and which team places their players first.

If a match has multiple games, competitors change colors at the start of each game.

If it is the last game of a match (*i.e. game 3 in a best-of-3 match*):

FRAMES: Players will start on the colors they played in game 1 and change colors halfway through the match.

POINTS: *Lag* will be played, (see below) prior to the final game of the match, and the winner chooses their color.

1.4.2 Lag

Lag is a tie-breaking game played by two opposing players shooting from the head of the court, attempting to shoot a disc as close as possible to, or onto, the far lag line. Yellow shoots a practice disc, followed by black. Both discs are then removed. Practice is repeated with each player's next two discs, *this can be shortened to one or zero*. The last disc shot by each player shall be left on the court. The disc closest to the far lag line wins. Measurement is from the center of the disc to the center of the lag line. If the last black disc shot touches the yellow disc, the yellow player wins.

1.4.3 Practice

Two rounds of practice are allowed by each player before the first and second games of a match. If a match has a color change (between games or after a set number of frames), two rounds of practice are allowed before the first frame on a new color. If the tournament is best of three, no practice is allowed in the third game.

In walking singles, players take one round from the head of the court and one from the foot.

Practice may be shortened by the TD, official, or if all players on the court agree.

1.4.4 Shooting Order

To start a game, play begins at the head of the court with the first frame. A frame is complete once all eight discs have been shot, in alternating color order (i.e., yellow, black, yellow, black, etc). Yellow shall always be played from right side of the head of court, and left side on the foot of the court.

A B			
-	7		
10	7		
3	15		
4	15		
12	5		
19	12		
19	12		
19	20		

In Frame 1, yellow shoots the first disc. Play alternates between colors until all discs are shot.

In Frames 2 and 3, black shoots the first disc.

In frame 4, yellow shoots the first disc. This pattern repeats until the game is complete.

NOTE: this order is YBBY; some clubs, leagues or tournaments will follow other orders, including YBYB and YYBB

Each tournament, league, or event will specify the shooting order prior to the start of play.

1.4.5 Error in Color Lead

Error in color lead shall be corrected if discovered before the frame is completed, by replaying the frame. Otherwise play continues in the correct game play order.

2. Rules

2.1 Spirit of the Game

Shuffleboard is a highly competitive strategy- and skill-based game, but competition should never be at the expense of the joy and respect of all players.

Arrive at your match on-time and well-prepared. Give the match and your competitors your full attention.

2.2 Penalty Enforcement

The Illinois Shuffleboard Association's Rules of Play are meant to ensure all players have an agreed-upon set of rules and expectations when competing with each other.

If a rule is broken during play, inform your opponent, as they may not be aware of the rule or how they are violating it.

Penalties will only be applied in officiated play. All assessments that a rule was violated and that warnings or penalties should be levied shall be made at the discretion of the TD or their official(s) (i.e. league manager for league finals).

If the outcome of a frame or match would not have changed due to a rule's first violation, continue play while ensuring all players on the court are aware of the rule moving forward. For any additional violations, or if the outcome could have changed, penalties may be assessed by the TD, or any official(s) they designate. Warnings may instead be given at the TDs or their official(s) discretion.

2.2.1 Severe Penalty

It could be advantageous for a player to intentionally or repeatedly violate a rule and accept the penalty, as it would be more net-positive points than the situation currently in the scoring area. In these cases, a "Severe Penalty" can be assessed by the TD or their official(s), in addition to the standard penalty. In case of a "Severe Penalty", all of the following actions will be taken:

- The offender's disc is removed
- If any of the offender's opponent's positive scoring discs were displaced, those discs will be:
 - immediately removed from the court
 - noted on the scoreboard as positive points for the offender's opponent to be added at the end of the frame
- If any of the offender's 10-Offs were displaced, those discs will be:
 - immediately removed from the court
 - noted on the scoreboard as -10 points each for the offender, to be added at the end of the frame

2.3 Play Area

2.3.1 Standing Area

The area between the baseline of the court and an imaginary line, even with the back of the bench, and bounded on the sides by the farthest line of each adjoining alley, should be considered part of the court.

Players may stand behind the baseline extension and in the alley between the courts, before or while shooting, but not on an adjoining court.

PENALTY: 5 OFF

2.3.2 Shooting Area

Players shall keep all four (4) of their discs within, but not touching, the lines of their respective half of the 10-off area. If a disc is played and other discs are touching the lines of the play area, PENALTY: 5 OFF

Discs must be played from within the respective half of the 10-off area. If a disc is played while touching the front or back line, PENALTY: 5 OFF

If a disc is played while touching the side of the 10-off area or dividing triangle. PENALTY: 10 OFF

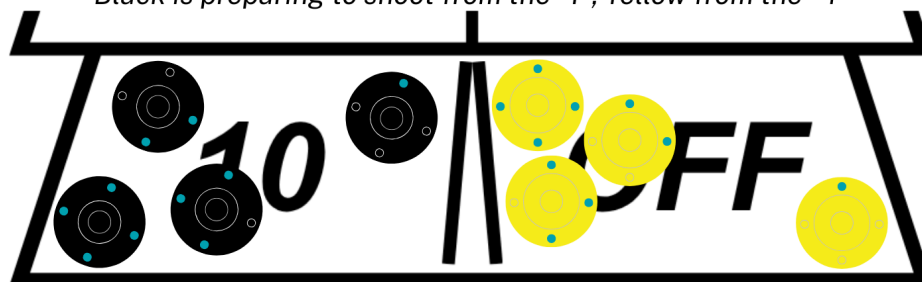
It is common practice with players to jockey or slide the playing disc backward and forward to see if there is any debris which might interfere with the disc sliding evenly. No penalty is to be called on this practice if lines are touched or crossed while jockeying. Discs in motion may cross the outside line.

A disc is played when it is completely in the seven area.

Valid shooting locations & disc placement:

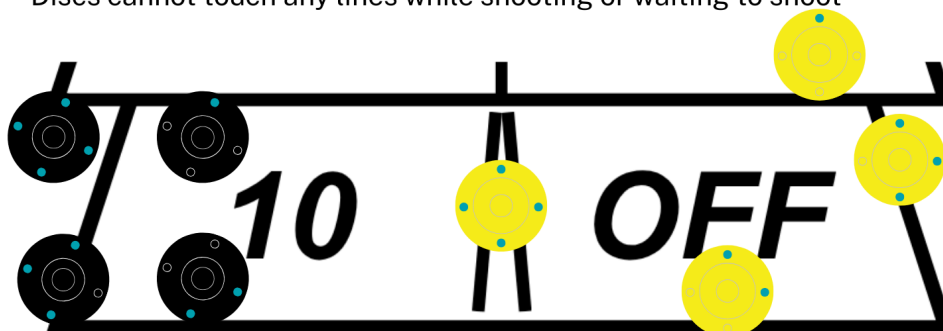
Keep all your discs within the kitchen, not touching any lines

Black is preparing to shoot from the "1"; Yellow from the "4"



Invalid disc placement:

Discs cannot touch any lines while shooting or waiting to shoot



2.4 Shot Delivery

2.4.1 Touching Court

Players must not touch a foot, hand, knee, or any other part of their body to the court on or over the base line or extension of baseline at any time while executing a shot.

PENALTY: 10 OFF

2.4.2 Hesitation Shot

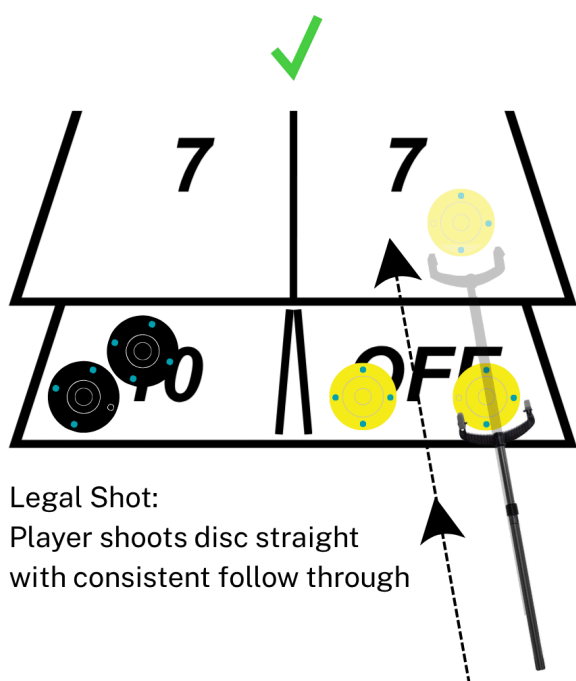
Once your shooting motion has begun, forward motion of your cue and disc must be continuous, with no hesitation or pause of that motion at any time while shooting.

PENALTY: 10 OFF

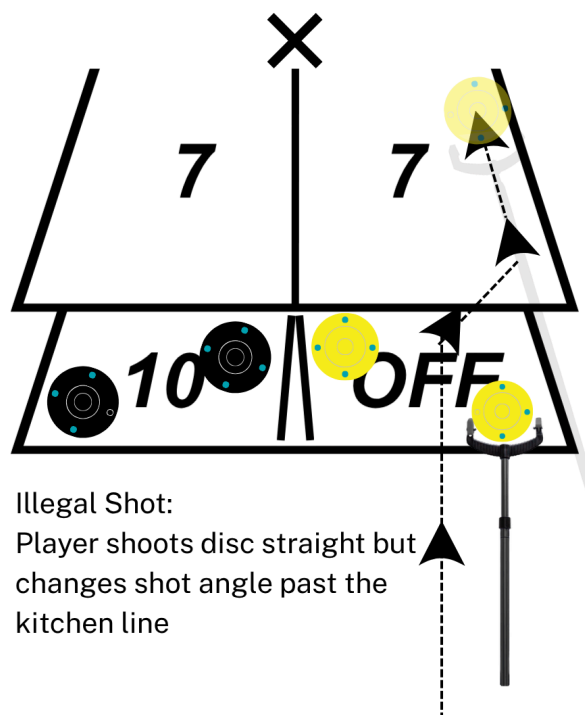
2.4.3 Hook Shot

A shot must be delivered in a straight line with continuous forward motion of the cue and disc.

PENALTY: 10 OFF



Legal Shot:
Player shoots disc straight
with consistent follow through



Illegal Shot:
Player shoots disc straight but
changes shot angle past the
kitchen line

2.4.4 Consecutive Discs

If a player shoots two discs in a row, without their opponent shooting a disc in between,
PENALTY: 10 OFF

2.5 Dead Discs

2.5.1 Types of Dead Discs

Remove any discs from the court (*gather within your standing area*) that meet any of the below criteria before continuing play:

- A disc that clearly leaves the court beyond the farthest base line, or goes off the sides of the court
- A disc stopping fewer than 8 inches beyond the farthest baseline
- A disc returning to or remaining on the playing area of the court, after having struck any object outside the playing area
- A disc that stops in front of the far lag line without touching it.
- A disc that is leaning over the edge of the court and touching the alley

2.5.2 Rebounds

If a dead disc rebounds and touches a live disc, or causes another dead disc to touch a live disc on the **same court**,

PENALTY: 5 OFF *for the player shooting the offending disc*

If this was the last disc of the frame, the score that was on the court immediately before the **rebound** shall count. Otherwise, the players closest to the impact reset discs back to where they were, if possible. If all players on the court agree with this placement, play continues. Otherwise the frame is replayed.

If a dead disc coming **from another court** touches a live disc, or causes another dead disc to touch a live disc,

PENALTY: 10 OFF *for the player shooting the offending disc on the other court*

The players closest to the impact reset discs back to where they were, if possible. If all players on the court agree with this placement, play continues. Otherwise the frame is replayed.

On some courts, shooting with significant force may be required to fully clear discs from the court. Before shooting forceful shots, **inform players** at the other end of the court, so that they may help prevent rebounds or prevent discs from striking players. If a player repeatedly shoots with force that, in the TD's discretion, poses a risk of harm to players or spectators, the TD may consider this [Other Improper Action](#) and levy penalties accordingly.

2.6 Other Rules

2.6.1 Code of Conduct

All players must follow the Illinois Shuffleboard Association's Code of Conduct, found in [Section 4](#). Players must not talk or make remarks to disconcert their opponent's play. Celebrate your victories; don't celebrate your opponent's misfortunes.

2.6.2 Coaching

Any remarks or motions to a teammate that indicates coaching is prohibited. Do not ask anyone on or off the court for advice.

PENALTY: 10 OFF

You may ask players on the other end of the court for clarification of the current game situation, but not in a leading way.

Examples:

Allowed: asking what the current score is

Prohibited: asking if you should intentionally “throw off” Allowed: asking how many and which discs are currently in scoring position

Prohibited: asking for advice on which shot to take

Allowed: asking how many inches over a line a disc is (a disc is 6” in diameter)

Prohibited: asking if there is enough room to replace a disc

Prohibited: pointing out a potential shot to your partner with your cue

2.6.3 Player Interference

Players shall not stand in the way of, have a cue in the way of, interfere with their opponent, or anyone shooting on a neighboring court, while they are executing a play.

PENALTY: 5 OFF

If a player touches a live disc at any time, a cue slips from a player's hand and touches a live disc, or a player shoots before their opponent's disc comes to rest,

PENALTY: 10 OFF

The players closest to the live discs reset discs back to where they were, if possible. If all players on the court agree with this placement, play continues. Otherwise the frame is replayed.

2.6.4 Delay of Game

A match will be forfeited if a player or team fails to appear within 15 minutes after the announced or scheduled start of a match.

Players must not leave the court during a game without permission, except to gather discs at the end of a frame. Return to court as quickly as possible.

PENALTY: 10 OFF

Players may take a short break between games. Players may not be gone for more than 10 minutes.

PENALTY: 10 OFF

2.6.5 On-the-clock

Players shall not, in the discretion of the TD or their official(s), unreasonably delay or stall the game, or negatively impact the overall schedule of a tournament. The TD or their official(s) may call out "slow play" and put the entire match on-the-clock.

While a match is on-the-clock, an official will time how long each disc takes to shoot, starting from when the previous disc stops (or players enter the shooting area in case of the first disc), until the disc leaves the cue. Timekeeping will be paused if the player is waiting for an adjacent court to clear the shooting area they wish to use. If a shot takes longer than 45 seconds, the player shooting that disc is penalized:

- 1st observed offense - Warning
- 2nd observed offense - PENALTY: 5-OFF
- 3rd observed offense - PENALTY: 10-OFF
- 4th observed offense - PENALTY: Player or Player's team forfeits the match

The official may cease timekeeping when they feel the match is back on track.

2.6.6 Substitutes

Once tournament play begins, there will be no substitutes allowed. Should any player not be able to continue, the player/team shall forfeit the remainder of tournament play.

2.6.7 Smoking

There is to be no smoking on the courts during a match.

2.6.8 Other Improper Action

In case of improper action of a player not specifically covered by the rules, the TD will ascertain the facts and may assess a penalty. They will also ensure that the offender gains no advantage from their improper action.

PENALTY: 10-OFF

3. Definitions

10-off area - The part of the scoring area on the opposite end of the court that is worth -10 points, also known as the "kitchen." Players must shoot all discs from this area on their end of the court.

Alley - The area between two courts.

Apex - The point at the top of the 10 in the scoring area.

Baseline - The line that separates the 10-off area from the standing area.

Biscuit - See "disc."

Cue - Equipment used to propel discs by players, also known as a "tang."

Dead disc - A disc that has been shot and needs to be removed from play.

Disc - Equipment that is propelled by cues, also known as a "biscuit."

Doubles - A game type where two teams of two people compete against each other, with one member from team A and B on each end of the court. See [Game Types](#).

End - The two short sides of the perimeter of the court, where players shoot from. A court has two ends, the head and the foot.

Foot - The end of the court that does not have the scoreboard.

Frame - A period where each player on a single end of the court shoots four discs each, alternating between each player.

Frame game - A game that is complete once a predetermined number of frames have been played. See [Game Types](#).

Gutter - See “Alley.”

Half-round - Not used in this ruleset. See “frame.”

Hammer - The last disc shot in a frame.

Head - The end of the court that has the scoreboard. Play begins from the head of the court.

Kitchen - See “10-off area.”

Live disc - A disc that has been shot, is in play, and has not entered any area that would make it a Dead Disc.

Non-walking singles - A game type where two individual people compete against one another, playing from a single end of the court; another match may happen simultaneously on the other end of the court. See [Game Types](#).

Points game - A game that is complete once a competitor has reached 75 points. See [Game Types](#).

Scoring area - The area of the court that players propel discs toward in order to earn points.

Shufflegram - See “scoring area.”

Side - The half of the court that each competitor’s discs start in. A court has two sides, yellow and black.

Singles - A game type where two individual people compete against one another. See [Game Types](#).

Starting area - See “10-off area.”

Throw off - Intentionally sending the disc off the court without interfering with live discs or reaching the shufflegram.

Out - i.e. “Yellow is out.” The player that goes first in a frame. See [Shooting Order](#) for which player “is out” in each frame.

Round - Not used in this ruleset. See “frame.”

Tang - See “Cue.”

TD - Tournament Director

Walking singles - A game type where two individual people compete against one another, playing odd-numbered frames from the head of the court (where the scoreboard is) and even-numbered frames from the foot of the court (the opposite end). See [Game Types](#).

4. Code of Conduct

As per the ILSA Constitution [Article VI](#), ratified on May 7, 2025 :

The following Code of Conduct represents the policy for the Illinois Shuffleboard Association. It applies to members, elected officials, committee members, instructors, players, referees, and spectators. The Code of Conduct will be enforced. Any member violating the intent of the policy may have their membership revoked.

1. Play the game with a spirit of good sportsmanship and act in a responsible manner. All players should conduct themselves in a manner that will ensure a welcoming, respectful, and comfortable environment for all.
2. Members must acknowledge that we are all representatives of a global shuffleboard community. As such, one must respect the age, spirituality, ethnic background and race, gender, sexual orientation, and disabilities of all persons involved.
3. There shall be no action as an attempt to intimidate, harass or demean opponents, teammates, officials, members, and spectators. This includes; threats, hurtful language, inappropriate disruption of events, unwanted sexual attention, bullying, or stalking - in person, online, or via social media.
4. Be aware of one's surroundings. Be courteous, responsible, and respectful.

5. History

The Illinois Shuffleboard Association's Rules of Play were originally drafted at ILSA's founding in 2022 and took much of their influence and spirit from The National Shuffleboard Association's Rules that were in place at the time.

In 2026, the board reviewed this document in its entirety for consistency and clarity. Version 2.0 further clarifies the sections put in place by the founding board to limit ambiguity and ease any necessary enforcement. Sections believed to be missing based on the existing content were added. Sub-sections were rearranged so that Section 1 contains how to play and Section 2 contains rules for any enforceable penalties. Automatic numbered list formatting was enabled as well as linked headings to ease future editing.